

Announcer [00:00:04–00:00:37]

Welcome to The Lighter Side of the Spectrum, the podcast that celebrates the multiple hats we wear and the juggling acts we perform in life. Whether you're parenting kids and teens on the autism spectrum, navigating the ever-evolving healthcare industry, or building a more inclusive and impactful world, this is your space to find connection, inspiration, and growth. Together, we'll share stories, tackle challenges, and explore how innovation and inclusion create better outcomes for everyone. Because no matter the spectrum, there's always a lighter side. Now here's your host, David Kaufer.

David Kaufer [00:00:37–00:02:53]

Hello again, everybody, and welcome back to The Lighter Side of the Spectrum. I'm so glad you're here. You know, one of the things I've noticed over the years is that every parent dreams about who their child might become someday. Maybe they'll be a doctor, an artist, a teacher. Maybe they'll have children of their own someday.

But none of us gets to write our children's story. We only get to walk beside them as it unfolds. And my guest today knows that journey all too well. She became a mom at just 19 years old. Her son Miles was, by her own description, a five-star baby.

Happy, easygoing, always smiling. As he grew older, though, she began noticing things that didn't quite fit. And when she asked questions, she was told not to worry. Boys mature more slowly. It wasn't autism.

But something inside of her kept saying, nope, there's more to the story. And that instinct eventually led to an autism diagnosis. It also led to years of learning and later an epilepsy diagnosis that finally explained symptoms no one had been able to make sense of. But her story didn't stop there. After Miles graduated from high school, she discovered what so many families eventually do, that the biggest challenges often become— often begin, excuse me, after school ends.

And instead of accepting that's just the way it is, she started asking questions, lots of questions. She researched how other states support adults with developmental disabilities. She met with lawmakers and eventually created a community that's helping people and families across Washington State navigate a system that few people truly understand until they're living it. Today we're going to talk about that journey.

We're going to talk about trusting your instincts as a parent, what families need to know before graduation, why asking better questions can lead to better answers, and why one young man with an unforgettable smile has changed more lives than he probably realizes. With all that being said, Angela Acres-Castro, welcome to The Lighter Side of the Spectrum.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:02:53–00:02:54]

Nice to be here.

David Kaufer [00:02:54–00:03:26]

Yeah, it's great having you here. I'm so glad that I came across you on Facebook, um, with your online advocacy. You know, one of the things I've learned over the years is that, you know, some of the most important voices in the autism community aren't actually the researchers or physicians or policymakers. They're parents like you, parents who never planned to become experts, but you became one just because you love someone who needed you to become one.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:03:26–00:03:40]

Well, and a little bit more about me is that we live in Eastern Washington, which is really small. So services are way more limited over here than they're going to be in the Seattle area.

David Kaufer [00:03:40–00:03:41]

Sure.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:03:41–00:03:55]

But I grew up here my whole life. My dad is originally from Seattle, so I spent a lot of time over there. I spent half my life walking around the Green Lake area because my grandma lived a block away.

David Kaufer [00:03:55–00:03:57]

Oh, nice. Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:03:57–00:04:02]

Yeah, yeah, yeah. So my dad went to Blanchette, Seattle U, all those.

David Kaufer [00:04:02–00:04:03]

Oh, right there. Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:04:03–00:04:21]

So when Miles, when he turned about 12, people started asking me, what's he going to do? And I don't think people realize this when they say this, are you going to put him in a group home? Well, I don't know.

He's 12.

Wow. So people asked you that at age 12?

Angela Acres-Castro [00:04:25–00:04:40]

Yeah. And well, I got that when he was 5, when he was diagnosed. The lens that we look at autism now is so different than it was in 2009. I mean, Jenny McCarthy came out with her book. She had me convinced it was vaccines that caused it.

David Kaufer [00:04:40–00:04:42]

Oh my gosh. Yeah. Okay. Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:04:42–00:04:45]

And she was the only one that was speaking about it publicly.

David Kaufer [00:04:45–00:04:47]

She was the only one talking about it. That's so true.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:04:47–00:05:49]

And I read her book and I felt myself in it. And it was, he developed typically, what looked typically, to me. I mean, he could talk. We can tell a story about how he was told not to touch the Christmas decoration. And he stood in front of the Christmas tree bent over saying, I looking, I not touching. I looking, I not touching. And then the thief that autism can be, it took that all away. And so, you know, and I, I saw myself in what she was saying. And it wasn't until I needed to get a vaccine while I was pregnant another time, and I said something to my doctor and he goes, you're too smart to fall for that. And it kind of woke me up and I was like, no, it's, you know, and it wasn't logical.

But when you have a child that's diagnosed at 5 and the doctor's giving you a pamphlet, you're looking for anything. Okay. Yeah, that's what it was. You're looking for answers why you're getting handed something so devastating to like—

David Kaufer [00:05:49–00:06:20]

Well, absolutely. And especially like you said, there was such a lack of information at that time. And it sounds like, you know, you dealt with something, um, that again, a lot of parents have dealt with, you know, to a certain degree, you know, which is like a level of regression, right? Like you said, you see some signs of typical development, but yet there's regression, or, you know, however you want to call it, arrested development, you know, just different things that, that as a parent, and again, as a young new parent, which you were, right? Like, you don't—

Yeah.

How do you— what do you know? Like, we don't know anything. We're just trying to keep our heads above water.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:06:25–00:06:44]

And it was, you know, oh, you don't, he does, you're talking for him, you're not letting it, you know, all these things. And a big part of Miles, which is like not typical, uh, or they, a reason, maybe I shouldn't phrase it that way, why the doctors wouldn't give me a referral is he was so affectionate. He sat on my lap.

David Kaufer [00:06:44–00:06:45]

Isn't that interesting?

Yeah.

He kissed me.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:06:46–00:06:52]

Oh, wow. I mean, like they would try to take him away from me and he was, didn't want them to.

David Kaufer [00:06:52–00:06:54]

Right.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:06:54–00:07:25]

You know, he ran to me when I'd go pick him up from daycare or my mom or— and I'm from a small town, so my best friends are my best friends that I had when I was 14. And he was kind of the community baby. So if I— and I was a hairdresser, so I worked long, late hours so he could be with my mom or any one of my best friends. And they took him all over town and did stuff with him. So he was like, A social butterfly. Everybody loved him. And so—

David Kaufer [00:07:25–00:07:33]

Which wasn't— like you said, that's not the way a kid with autism is supposed to be. They're supposed to be antisocial, right? Not show emotions.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:07:33–00:07:49]

Yeah. No, he— and he was happy, you know, still even now to this day, if he sees someone from his childhood, he had a long-term daycare provider and her son, he thought, looked like Mr. Bleekman after Mr. Bleekman, off of Clifford the Big Red Dog.

Announcer [00:07:49–00:07:50]

Oh.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:07:50–00:08:15]

So he'd always call the babysitter's son Mr. Bleakman, and he's— the babysitter's son is a teacher at the high school. So he walks up to him and asks— talks to him and says, hi, Mr. Bleakman. And he's like, hi, Miles. I mean, it's not— his name's Aaron. So it's just kind of— he's very— remembers everything, very social and friendly, and he's completely lovable. So he—

David Kaufer [00:08:15–00:08:16]

It sounds like it. Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:08:17–00:08:32]

Doctors would just say, no, he's too bonded to you. Autistic kids aren't like that. But, you know, he did a lot of the stimming. He spins faster than any person I know. And he's done that from the time he was little and he still does it now.

David Kaufer [00:08:32–00:08:34]

Oh, does he? Okay.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:08:34–00:08:53]

So yeah. And, you know, and I noticed too growing up or with him growing up and me with him is that they assume because a lot of autistic people like it, that he's gonna like it. So like one thing, because he goes a mile a minute too, um, is they thought he'd like a weighted vest.

David Kaufer [00:08:53–00:08:55]

Yeah. Oh yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:08:55–00:09:05]

And he put it— it was like I couldn't help but laugh, but they put them on him. He's like, help, help, help, I'm stuck, I'm stuck, help! Like, because he didn't like that sensation.

David Kaufer [00:09:05–00:09:06]

He didn't like it.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:09:06–00:09:19]

But he'll wrap his legs as tight as he possibly can for 15 minutes and then spread it out and spend a half hour tacking his legs just the right way to get that deep pressure that he's looking for.

David Kaufer [00:09:19–00:09:20]

That deep pressure, right.

Announcer [00:09:20–00:09:21]

Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:09:21–00:09:28]

Right. As I say again, he's obviously a sensory seeker, as many of our guys and gals are.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:09:28–00:09:48]

And another thing they brought up, they're like, well, he only wants food. And I mean, he does have his favorite meals, but so do I. I order the same thing at every restaurant I go over and over. So my dad did, my sisters do. So I didn't think of anything like this. But he like eats tomatoes, watermelon, spaghetti, salad.

Announcer [00:09:48–00:09:49]

Wow.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:09:49–00:09:50]

Yeah. Like—

That's great.

He likes cheeseburgers. He has his favorite meals, but he's not one of those kids that will, like the doctor referred, only eat chicken nuggets or only eat rice. Like he ate several different foods.

David Kaufer [00:10:04–00:10:09]

Like it wasn't like I don't know if he didn't fit the box. It sounds like that.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:10:09–00:10:29]

Every time they were like, no. And I'm like, but he couldn't follow directions. Like, and he'd elope. Like, oh, so it was— there was other bigger signs. But the things that they're like, well, that's not him. Because he doesn't do this. He's just got a speech delay. And boys are wild was essentially what I was told.

David Kaufer [00:10:29–00:10:41]

Boys are wild and boys are slower. Did you ever also get that too? Yeah, all the time. Slower. You know, just something. Sometimes they're just slower to talk or slower to develop.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:10:41–00:11:16]

Yeah. Well, and another thing, he was, you know, I just knew that for years I'd been around. I come from a big family, so my nieces and nephews are actually closer in age to me than my sisters. And so, uh, some of them. And so I had, when I was a teen, like preteen and teenager, I had nieces and nephews and I just knew that you, potty trained 3-year-olds. And so I potty trained him at 3. And that was another thing that they told me, oh no, you had him potty trained. Autistic kids can't be potty trained that young.

David Kaufer [00:11:16–00:11:18]

Can't be potty trained.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:11:18–00:11:23]

That young. They said it normally takes them till 7 or 8, which some kids do take that long.

Announcer [00:11:23–00:11:23]

Sure.

Yeah.

But I, I mean, I didn't know that it was hard, but I was like, no, he's 3. He has to be potty trained. Like, they won't let him go to preschool if he's not potty trained. So I did it.

David Kaufer [00:11:37–00:11:42]

And so when did he get that? You said he was 5 when you finally—

Angela Acres-Castro [00:11:42–00:12:46]

He was 5. And so what happened is we switched clinics and somehow I just knew to tell the doctor. I was like, hey, I'm worried and everybody tells me it's in my head, but I would stop worrying if I could go to a developmental pediatrician and they could tell me that it's all in my head. But no, but if it's not,

then I need it. I need to know what's going on.

And so finally, he, the head doctor was like, well, you're the mom, you know? So he's like, yeah, I'll send. And I told him, I go, he's not like other kids that I've been around. And so we went, there was a cancellation. I went, she gave me the diagnosis.

I started crying and he kissed me and said, it's okay, Mommy. And we left and we've been on our journey since. And I gave myself, again, through the lens, I wasn't grieving Miles. I was grieving what I thought our future was going to look like.

David Kaufer [00:12:46–00:12:47]

Of course.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:12:47–00:13:25]

And it was totally different. You know, like when he was born, he was He was just absolutely beautiful, like one of the most beautiful babies I'd ever seen. And it was like I pictured him playing sports, dating, having a lot of friends. And he does have a lot of friends and everything. It's just not how I would picture his life would be. And, you know, we're great. We're better than great. He's fantastic. And like— Some of my friends have kids and like their kids They're teenagers, they don't get along. I'm like, my kid loves to be with me all the time. He just like, I'm his favorite person.

David Kaufer [00:13:25–00:13:36]

That's a real, yeah, that's a wonderful perspective. And it's true, right? Like there are some real benefits that come with that, that the level of the relationship is just—

Angela Acres-Castro [00:13:36–00:13:44]

Like, he, like, yeah, he's, I mean, I know he thinks I'm annoying and he doesn't mean he didn't mock me at times, but he—

David Kaufer [00:13:44–00:13:46]

Well, he wouldn't be a son if he didn't.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:13:47–00:14:01]

He— but he, he, he's never not like loved being with me, you know? So it— that, that was like what made me like, oh God, like, I don't know how to help you.

David Kaufer [00:14:01–00:14:11]

Yeah, you said— so you said you cried when you got the diagnosis. Was it— was there any of that? Was it— was it all like— so was it all grief or was it also some of it relief? I wonder.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:14:11–00:14:38]

It was relief because it was like I'm not crazy. Yeah, I'm not crazy. There was something different. And you guys kept on telling me like, no, he's just— give him a few years and he'll talk. And it was like, you know, and it opened— if we had the services, it would've opened the door to more. Well, actually, that's not true because— and I know ABA is kind of controversial with some people.

Oh yeah.

So I'm not saying— I'm not, advocating for or against. But at the time when he was diagnosed, it was not even covered. And I did because he eloped and we lived near a lake, all that. And he liked water.

Yeah, he liked water.

Of course. Yeah.

He loved it.

David Kaufer [00:14:58–00:14:59]

Little fish.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:14:59–00:15:17]

And there was probably 3 years where I didn't sleep unless he was at a relative's house away from us because I was afraid he was— and he has sleep issues. Like, he'll— he can be up even now for 36 hours, even with a sleep med. So—

Announcer [00:15:17–00:15:18]

Wow.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:15:18–00:15:52]

Yeah, yeah, it's fun times, right? He— it's like, I am like, oh. But, um, I was afraid he'd get up and go swim in the lake. And so I did find— and mind you, minimum wage was like \$9-something. I think I made 11:50 as a cosmetology instructor, because I've had many careers over my life. And I would pay out of pocket to go to this lady for 1 hour a week for like, it was like \$115 for that 1 hour.

Wow.

And we worked on him staying, not going outside without, because he'd go outside and you couldn't catch him. Ran. I always pictured him like a sphinx or one of those half-human monsters.

David Kaufer [00:16:06–00:16:07]

Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:16:07–00:16:56]

Where he'd just see you get close enough to where you could catch him and then he'd gallop away. And so— It's a game. Oh, and his favorite game. And subsequently his little brother likes to play the same game. He's neurotypical and he calls it Catch the Elf and he's the elf.

So that's fun. But I had to, and we had locks up high, all those things to keep him from getting out. But he's really smart. He can't ask you how to do something, so he watches. So he figured out if he pushed a stool next to the door, he could reach that lock.

And an Angel Lock or anything, that was like child's play to him. Because he's smart. Like, nice try. Just took me an extra minute. So it gave me an extra minute to catch him.

Trying to sneak outside.

David Kaufer [00:16:56–00:17:05]

Wow. Wow. Yeah, that's a lot. So, and again, you're dealing with all this, I take it, again, as a single mom, right?

Angela Acres-Castro [00:17:05–00:17:07]

Yeah. Yeah, it was.

David Kaufer [00:17:07–00:17:12]

I mean, it sounds like you had support. You talk about, you know, friends and family and support. But again, you're still— I mean, it's—

Angela Acres-Castro [00:17:12–00:18:00]

And my mom, I can't even give my mom enough credit for how much she— I couldn't have done it. I couldn't have worked. I really couldn't have done it without my mom. She was my other co-parent. She helped, you know, she just, she is still my rock.

And I still, she's 81 or gonna be 82. And last summer she was at Silverwood after playing keno all night. And the year before was walking around Boston 3 days straight. And the 3rd day she's like, my knee hurts. Can we sit down?

And she felt bad about it. Um, and I was like, you're gonna be 81 or 80. It's okay if you have to take a break. My mom's an animal.

David Kaufer [00:18:00–00:18:22]

Like, she sounds like it. She sounds awesome. She is. That's great. That's— it's obviously made a huge difference to have that, you know, like you said, like, I like how you kind of referred to us almost a co-parent and having that kind of resource. Because again, it's so hard. I mean, there's just a lot— the lack of sleep. I mean, there's just You know, there's just a lot to deal with, especially when they're young.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:18:22–00:19:11]

Well, and what, when we're not having the appropriate services to help during the day, um, you know, we depend on that. But also, like, I, in researching different states, I was like, well, I'm gonna, shocking, like, I'm gonna move to North Dakota. And they have a great system. They had a huge lawsuit in the '80s that just transform the way they did things. But then I leave my support. I leave my mom, my husband's family, and something we even talked about Spokane at one point, but that's really not fair to us to leave. And my husband is just like a rockstar. He said—

Announcer [00:19:11–00:19:11]

Right.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:19:12–00:19:17]

He goes, that's fine. We can look into it. I can work wherever. He's an electrician. Okay. Yeah.

But he said, the thing is, he was like, name my 5 best friends I talk to every day. And he was like, I know you don't go over and hang out because you don't like to leave the house after 4 o'clock. But he said, right now, if you want to drive over there, like at most like a 15-minute drive, And he said, we move to any of these places, you're going to have to make an effort to drive over. I've got a 16-year-old who, you know, her life's here. We've got extended family.

David Kaufer [00:19:51–00:19:53]

Middle of high school. Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:19:53–00:20:07]

And another thing I was thinking about, people around the community know Miles. So he's part of this community. So I take him out, we go where police officers don't know him, you know, the restaurant. Right. Right. All these things you have to think about.

David Kaufer [00:20:09–00:20:09]

Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:20:10–00:20:16]

And he is a little bit of a klepto at the store. And so one of his—

David Kaufer [00:20:16–00:20:23]

That's not uncommon, right? Like, sometimes they just, you know, it's not intentional. It's just kind of like, I think, kind of like an impulsive thing.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:20:23–00:20:54]

Yeah. Well, what he does is he just opens food and starts eating it. And then, you know, and so I, like, one of his IEP goals was before he could ever eat his lunch or anything, he had to give the person's lunch card. So he got that idea that you can't eat it until after you get the card. So whether or not— he doesn't care whether there's money, but at least he got the principle that he couldn't eat it without giving that card. That card was his go-ahead to eat.

Yeah.

So, um, but, you know, he hasn't been tackled for shoplifting in our local community because they know I'm going to pay for it. You know, they know that, right? Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:21:04–00:21:06]

They know, they know, they know.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:21:06–00:21:13]

They know I'm not purposely trying to shoplift some Mike and Ikes, you know.

David Kaufer [00:21:13–00:21:16]

So, you know, it's so—

Angela Acres-Castro [00:21:16–00:21:21]

Yeah, he does too. And I think they're disgusting. But, you know, whatever.

David Kaufer [00:21:21–00:21:36]

You know, one of the things you mentioned ahead of time, you know, as we were kind of debriefing and just kind of talking about the journey or whatever, is he also has epilepsy. Um, and that was diagnosed right at age 18.

18.

Um, do you— yeah. So you want to talk about that? Because I think you had mentioned that.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:21:40–00:21:41]

Yes.

David Kaufer [00:21:41–00:21:48]

You weren't really sure about that either, right? Again, it was— this is one of the challenges that came with the communication.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:21:48–00:22:14]

So for a lot, he, he didn't— like, starting age 3, he didn't nap. And it would— like, I would try everything, turn off noise. Like, he just wasn't a sleeper. And then randomly he'd like throw up and take a nap. And it'd be, and I remember like one time he did it when he was little. And if you're familiar with your Eastern Washington, I was driving from Tri-Cities back to Moses Lake and it's like an hour drive. Oh.

And I was with one of my best friends and we like had to pull off and it's on Highway 17, which is a scary highway, 'cause we thought he died 'cause he was, fell asleep. So we were like, oh my, this, kid that does not nap. And he'd randomly start throwing up and then taking these naps. And then one time, it was every Sunday for a month, he'd throw up and go take a nap. And so I took him in. We were like, is it migraines? Is it—

David Kaufer [00:22:43–00:22:44]

Right.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:22:44–00:23:07]

What is this? And so just monitor. I mean, he can't say what it is. And then he was Oddly enough, on the school bus, and I happened to drive past taking one of his siblings to junior high or something, um, and I see the school bus pull over and there's an ambulance there, and I'm like, that's weird.

David Kaufer [00:23:07–00:23:10]

That's not normal.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:23:10–00:23:33]

I hope something— everything's okay. Well, then I, I probably talk to my sister every morning when I'm dropping my Doing stuff with my kids. So I think I'm on the phone with my sister talking about Sister Wives or something, and I get a call from the bus garage and they're like, Miles just had a grand mal seizure on the bus. He's at the emergency room.

David Kaufer [00:23:33–00:23:36]

How old was he? I'm sorry, how old was he?

Angela Acres-Castro [00:23:36–00:23:38]

So he was 16 then.

Okay. Okay.

And so, and we still didn't connect that to the throwing up randomly. Sure. Right. And so, and it was really long and I had to fight for an aide to be on the bus with him to supervise that just in case. And they did it for 1 year. And then again, he was probably having the seizures that we didn't know that that was what it was. And then he ended up, and then whatever, he goes to the doctor, ER doc follow-up, and they said, everybody's allowed 1 seizure in their life and it's not epilepsy. So we're not going to diagnose him. It was just one of those random things.

David Kaufer [00:24:18–00:24:19]

Could be one and a half of them.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:24:19–00:24:39]

Yeah. Yep. So we're not going to worry too much. Just make sure, whatever. Well, and so then he was 18 and I get another phone call and he had, I think when the nurse watched it, it was a 14-minute seizure.

David Kaufer [00:24:40–00:24:41]

Oh my gosh.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:24:41–00:24:50]

Yeah. And so, and they wouldn't let me watch it because of privacy reasons, but they sent it to his neurologist. And so— That's odd.

Announcer [00:24:50–00:24:51]

Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:24:51–00:24:55]

I mean, I guess because he was 18, but still, you're his mom. Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:24:55–00:25:30]

I'm like, well, yeah, I'm like, I guess, but I still choose which, like, I still buy all his clothes. Like, like, yeah. So they sent it to the neurologist. The neurologist was very alarmed. Well, another thing that people— so I— not every— this is just my experience, but autism and puberty were an absolute hell that I will— it was literally like, I cannot— I mean, he's— but he's also like typical. So he's got aggression and all like whatever.

David Kaufer [00:25:30–00:25:33]

Hormones are going crazy.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:25:34–00:26:01]

So we had to be really careful with— and I'm his mom, so of course he's going to be like my other kids. They are the least pleasant people to me out of everybody because he knows I love him, right? So he got really aggressive with me through puberty and all that. And I had to make sure when he went on a seizure— his little sister also had childhood epilepsy. She grew out of it.

David Kaufer [00:26:01–00:26:02]

Okay.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:26:02–00:26:15]

But so I was familiar that some of the epileptic medication makes you a real jerk, and it's different when it's on a 15-month-old baby than it is on an 18-year-old man.

David Kaufer [00:26:15–00:26:16]

Yeah, right.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:26:16–00:26:42]

So one of the better drugs, I was like, hey, I can't do that. He already gets aggressive with me. So if you put him on that, I'm not gonna be able to keep him at home because I, he's now, I mean, it was one thing when he was smaller than me, but now that he's bigger than me, I, I can't have him taking something that's gonna make him aggressive. So we had to go with the medication that probably isn't the best at controlling.

David Kaufer [00:26:42–00:26:43]

Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:26:43–00:26:46]

You know, I had to weigh the pros and cons and it was like—

Absolutely.

And I couldn't do a month of aggressive behavior to get You know, it wouldn't have been fair for either one of us. So he did. And actually this Wednesday, I was sitting somewhere and I heard a loud thud, like maybe like the wind shut the door. And I was like, that seemed like too hard to even slam. And I sat there for about 3 or 4 minutes.

And then I was like, I wonder what— I was like, I'm going to just go because that doesn't sound like the door that— would've slammed by the wind. So I went to go check and Miles was slumped over having a grand mal seizure. And he's got a 4-year-old sister who follows me up. She's screaming and crying. I'm trying to call 911 because somehow they had— he has a rescue inhaler.

I broke it because my hands were shaking. And so I'm like, okay, right. 911, thinking maybe he needs to be Picked up or whatever, and she's screaming and crying, and he's got Black Eyed Peas blaring in the background. I just finally had to rip out and unplug the TV as loud as he possibly could. The 911 operator's telling me, I can't hear you, because it was so long, it wasn't stopping.

And so finally it did stop. And something that happens, it's that he urinated. And so they were like, well, do you want to—

David Kaufer [00:28:12–00:28:13]

Yeah, during the seizure.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:28:13–00:28:32]

Yeah. And they're like, do you want us to come get you? It stopped and I was able to find another rescue inhaler that I didn't break. So I— Oh, that's good. Yeah. I was like, I don't want him to go have to— I can't give him a shower. I don't want him to ride up in the ambulance with— even if I change his pants, which I don't— that's gonna be fun.

David Kaufer [00:28:32–00:28:33]

I can see that. Right.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:28:33–00:29:03]

Yeah. He's in that postictal state where he's not moving or can't— he's not in control of his body really. And so I was like, it's just better to just let him sleep it off. And I just kept on coming in every 15 minutes to make sure he wasn't having it. Yeah. And then I let him sleep it off. And, you know, he loves a bath, but he had to take a shower because if he falls in the shower, his chances of drowning are way less than a bath. So it just—

David Kaufer [00:29:03–00:29:10]

It's so hard. So how many, or how frequently has he had seizures?

Angela Acres-Castro [00:29:10–00:29:15]

It's random. And I think what happened that day, we have so much smoke here from the fires.

David Kaufer [00:29:15–00:29:16]

Right, right.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:29:16–00:29:53]

And he's a creature, so it's really hot, like traps in all this heat. And he's a creature of habit. So like he thinks every day he has to get jeans on. And I'm like, no, shorts. It's too hot. And he had his jeans on before I had a chance to catch him. Well, he went outside to dink around and sit on the trampoline and he— or yeah, something. He was doing something. And then he came back in and he was just drenched in sweat. So I think he got overheated.

Yeah.

But then the last one, I was at the grocery store. He was with my mom. My mom calls me and said he was sitting up. She was like, you have to come right back home. He was sitting on the couch. It was like right around Thanksgiving. So I think it was like a Tuesday before, and I was trying to get there before the rush, and he had a grand mal seizure on the couch. So it's like we don't ever really know.

David Kaufer [00:30:15–00:30:19]

It's, it's so unpredictable, right?

Announcer [00:30:19–00:30:20]

Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:30:20–00:30:56]

I think that's one of the things that's hard. And I say this, I don't— I mentioned this to you before, but we deal with it, Angie. So again, I have a 20-year-old non-speaking son who We've had to deal with it for about 5 years. I think it was 5 or 6 years ago when he had— 5 years ago. And yeah, it's really hard, you know, it's really unpredictable.

Um, you know, we track them, he's on medication, we're trying to monitor the medication. I don't know if you've dealt with this in terms of, like you said, sometimes the medication can give brain fog, right?

Like, you know, in terms of like affecting them that way, it's, it's, it's a balancing act.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:30:56–00:30:58]

Oh, yeah.

David Kaufer [00:30:58–00:30:59]

I'm just— I'm really—

Angela Acres-Castro [00:30:59–00:31:24]

And then the levels and all that. And it's just stuff that you don't even think about. And another thing

that really was fun one time, so he's on several medications and he had COVID, and so it did something to his taste. So he refused to take any medicine for 2 weeks. So it—

David Kaufer [00:31:25–00:31:29]

I mean, that did something to the brain, you know, right? Because again, it's—

Angela Acres-Castro [00:31:29–00:31:37]

Yeah. And, you know, he's on medication for anxiety, so he, he was not getting anything. He wouldn't do it.

David Kaufer [00:31:37–00:31:38]

Wow.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:31:38–00:32:13]

Yeah, it was, it was off. And it was like, you know, the school didn't tell me to pull him out, but I'm like, he's miserable, they're miserable. And he, he loves his siblings. Like, that's very clear to me. Every single one of them, they drive him nuts. They're bossy, but Even his little brother, he loved so much, but he couldn't be around him because they were so— they just like hurt every— it wasn't— it hurt every sense that he had because every noise someone made, um, just— he couldn't handle it.

Announcer [00:32:13–00:32:14]

Right.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:32:14–00:32:52]

Yeah. So my husband kept, um, all the 5 other kids. Including his sister that's closest in his age, and they're full siblings with him. And my mom and I just had him. I took him on drives, he had all the baths, but it was like you could just tell he was just miserable. And then I was afraid to take him to the emergency room because I'm like, they're going to strap him down, they're going to shoot him up with all this medication. And They're going to send him to Eastern Hospital and I'm not going to be next to him and it's just going to make everything worse.

David Kaufer [00:32:52–00:32:53]

So much shame.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:32:53–00:33:39]

So we just rode the storm out until we could. And I kept on calling his regular doctor and we're from a small town, so he's had the same doctors for years too. And his assistant kept on saying, well, go take him to the emergency room. And I was like, I don't I can't take 'em to the emergency room. It's gonna make things worse.

And so finally when he got into his regular doctor, he's like, why didn't you call me and get in the, the day that you noticed it? I was like, I tried, but your assistant. And so he did tell her if she calls because there's an emergency, I don't care where you stick 'em, put 'em on the schedule. They've been miserable for 2 weeks. And then we were able to get 'em leveled, leveled out and everything.

Wow.

So there, yeah, it's like stuff that people don't think of and it, It becomes so second nature to you as a parent that you don't realize how hard the stuff is that you're dealing with. It's just part of your life.

David Kaufer [00:33:51–00:33:52]

It's just what you do.

Yeah.

It's just what you do.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:33:53–00:33:53]

Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:33:54–00:34:05]

I mean, it's funny. Again, you mentioned that we are on a form of seizure watch today because one of the triggers we've noticed with Stone is lack of sleep.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:34:05–00:34:06]

Oh yeah.

Yep.

Right? That's another one. And so like this morning, so he's, I think I mentioned to you ahead of time, he's He's at summer camp this week. There's a great program, Outdoors for All, here. He goes to a day camp.

Oh, nice.

Yeah, it's really, it's a really great program. Um, and, you know, every day they do something different. Today is swimming day. So, you know, we're talking about the love of water, swimming, right?

Favorite thing in the world. He was so jacked that he got up at like 4:30 in the morning.

Announcer [00:34:30–00:34:31]

Oh.

David Kaufer [00:34:31–00:34:46]

Right? So, you know, that, right, that alone kind of raises the level, right? We have, you know, We're used to fire dangers in summer, right? And you hear about like, where's the fire danger? Now it's kind of like the seizure danger warning.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:34:46–00:34:46]

Okay.

David Kaufer [00:34:47–00:34:51]

Yeah. So far so good. But like you said, it becomes second nature.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:34:51–00:35:29]

Oh yeah, totally. I remember somebody asked me that was observing him, how many times did you tell him, explain the sequence of events? And I was like, I don't know, maybe 3. And they're like, I counted 17. 5 minutes.

Well, it becomes like background noise. You just do it. It just becomes— the only thing I can compare is like, if you— humans' brains train themselves to see past their nose so it's not in their vision. So it's like the same thing when I'm like, you know, when he's doing repetitive things that I have to address constantly. I don't notice I'm doing it all the time, but other people do.

David Kaufer [00:35:29–00:35:50]

That's a great analogy. You're right. You're right. Yeah. It's just part of life. I want to, um, I want to jump ahead a little bit, Angie, because again, one of the reasons we connected was, you know, through the Facebook page you started. And one of the things I love is, again, that you've become an advocate yourself. And I know, or I believe, you didn't plan on becoming an advocate.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:35:50–00:35:52]

Oh no, not at all.

David Kaufer [00:35:52–00:36:10]

You tried, you know, you're— you kind of became one because you tried, you know, working inside the system, and you're like, notice things aren't working, and Why can you talk about that a little bit? Just give a brief background and kind of where we're at with what you're doing.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:36:10–00:37:09]

So kind of just to explain, I love policy, not just politics, but understanding coalitions and understanding how things work. I'm a human interest person, all that kind of stuff. And I'm really good at history, like all these things that would kind of, you'd need to like to be interested in this kind of thing. And so, and I remember things like one person will say like a little small something and then I'll remember it and then I'll look it up and then I'll go down these rabbit holes. Like I know way too much about random information that no sane person should know.

And so when he was about 14, like I said, people were like, are you going to put him in a group home? All this stuff that now I'm like, they didn't deserve that information and they shouldn't have been asking that.

David Kaufer [00:37:09–00:37:10]

Right.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:37:10–00:37:37]

But it did make me think, what am I going to— I mean, I knew what was coming. I mean, it's inevitable. And I would go meet candidates running for office and I'd say, what are you going to do? They didn't know what to do. They were like, well, I didn't know this was an issue. And it's like, of course you wouldn't. Because if you're not personally impacted by this, you're not going to know, right?

David Kaufer [00:37:37–00:37:39]

It's invisible, right?

Angela Acres-Castro [00:37:39–00:38:02]

Yeah. And because I think Miles is absolutely wonderful. Every parent, we remember that first time our kid was judged, right? We remember that first time that somebody looked at our kid and was like, they're different than every other kid. And And you remember that feeling of sadness and shame and everything that came along.

Yeah.

So we train ourselves never to talk about the most difficult parts of being a caregiver of somebody with autism. You know that they can't help it, but you don't want them thinking your kid is weird or strange or anything like that. So you keep those parts separate to protect your child's dignity. And there's so many great stories. You can work with the right supports and it's like, okay, that's great.

And so I'm going to these parent meetings type things where you have to do training for some— I had to do training for something. And I'm sitting in this class and it's like, there are these— this dad, he had twins that had Down syndrome and his wife had cancer and she they couldn't both attend her medical appointments because they couldn't— and this is a whole nother issue, but they couldn't find caregivers for them to—

Wow.

Watch their— or not watch, but be there with their kids while they went to the appointments together. And because they had nowhere for them to go during the day. So, and then another mom, her daughter had been out of high school 2 years, and I can't remember exactly But once her daughter didn't have somewhere to go and the structure was gone, behaviors, she was dealing with behaviors that she didn't think that she could have her at home, but she was afraid to place her in some sort of supported living situation because she was afraid of sexual abuse and stuff like that.

Sure.

Absolutely. And so she was just, I mean, this woman, I just I mean, they were making me cry. I was crying and I was just like, this shouldn't be this way. This should not be— life should not be this hard. There has to be somewhere to go for people to go so that they're not isolated at home and taking that frustration from being stuck at home out on their parents. And these people can go to the doctors. A married couple can go to a doctor's—

David Kaufer [00:40:10–00:40:12]

Go to a cancer doctor's appointment.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:40:12–00:42:05]

Yeah. And so therefore, and I had gotten friendly with some caseworkers, and I said something and one of them said, oh yeah, you can do it. And she gave it to me. Well, you can, but it's under COPES and the reimbursement rate is only \$89 a day. And there was all this red tape and I'll make a post on it eventually because I really went down that.

And especially where I lived, Half of— there are maybe 13 programs around the state that do this, but they depend really on philanthropy to sustain the program. And you have to use respite cares. It's not a replacement for a day program. And so I met with my representative and he's very, very great, supportive, all that. He is a wonderful man.

by anybody that you talk to around the state. But it just didn't make— how are you supposed to run that? And then I talked to another caseworker that I had gotten friendly with, and she's telling me about

community inclusion, all these programs. And I was like, but that's not enough to replace school. And so she told me, well, we can't do that because there was a lawsuit.

Well, I'm not a genius, but I do know how to look up case law. On the internet. So I'm like, okay. So I go down, I'm spending hours trying to figure out what case. I mean, I could tell you why we don't have an income tax.

It deals with some case that went through the Supreme Court in the 1910s or '30s through a farmer in Washington where it was ruled unconstitutional. So I know how to look up case law. So then finally I was like, there's no case law. She's not— that's not true. And so I called her back and I was like, could you tell me specifically what case—

David Kaufer [00:42:05–00:42:06]

Which case?

Angela Acres-Castro [00:42:06–00:42:32]

You're referring to? And I said, because I can't find it. And I was— she's like, well, you're maybe not typing in the right terms. I was like, no, I've typed in every single term that I can figure out where this lawsuit came out of, and there was no lawsuit saying what you're telling me it said. And I was like, I go, I love you, but don't ever tell another parent that because I thought you thought I was stupid when you told me that. And then—

Oh.

And I was like, you know, don't, you know, there is, don't, that is, there's no lawsuit. Well, I think now what she's referring to the Supreme Court case and what that did is it made a settings rule and every state has to follow that settings rule, right? And I forget the exact name. So Washington State has chosen to, like, over— in my opinion, has overinterpreted it compared to other states because many other states have day programs. Like, we're one of the very few that don't.

David Kaufer [00:43:08–00:43:10]

Really?

Angela Acres-Castro [00:43:10–00:43:17]

Yeah. And so when— and I remember watching something on PBS, like, I'm a big PBS person.

David Kaufer [00:43:17–00:43:18]

Yeah, I love PBS.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:43:18–00:44:02]

And watching something on autism and they had day programs. So from that, I knew that watching that, that other states had them. And so when she was like, well, we're not going to, kind of trying to talk me out of it. And so finally I said, would you not agree the way the current system is set up leaves a huge donut hole of people that are going to be sitting at home doing nothing? And so finally she gave me that.

And then it kind of, and she was like, then she brought up the settings rule. Well, then that's when I knew these other places. My twins were asleep and the other kids, like, they were little, they were probably a year old or whatever. And twins are another beast of their own. They are actually a lot harder than—

Oh yeah.

Like, I didn't baby-proof for Miles other than doors. My twins, everything was baby-proofed at everybody's house that they spent any amount of time at 'cause they were wild. And so I just started calling other states. I called North Dakota, Idaho, California, Massachusetts, and Arizona, and they all had something. So then I would call their DSHS offices or similar, and I'd talk to them about regulations.

And like, I remember asking them, I was like, are you guys using Medicaid dollars? And they're like, yeah. And so I was being told in Washington you couldn't use Medicaid dollars. And then every other state's like, well, yeah, how else would we fund them without Medicaid? It's like a waiver option.

Right, right.

And I was like, whoa. And so I was like, well, that's not true. And so then I was calling anybody around the state I could, organizations. And then I was even talking to people that were running for office or that were in office, but this wasn't where they're— they weren't on this specific committee that would deal with this, and they didn't know. And like, one of them, I remember he was— and this isn't a political issue to me, this is a policy thing, right? People on the right and left, um, can have members with intellectual and developmental disabilities. So this is for everyone.

David Kaufer [00:45:27–00:45:28]

Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:45:28–00:46:09]

And, um, I was talking to a Democrat that was in elected office, and I, and I was like, I want to move to North Dakota. And he was like, whoa, And I was like, yeah. I was like, they blow us out of the water. And so they would try to help get me, and sometimes I'd get somewhere and it was like they wanted me to just shut up. They didn't want me to talk.

And so I tried to post in a few areas that I thought, on private pages on Facebook, where I thought people that could help me would see it and they would understand. Because I I always just figured people didn't know. If they knew, then they would want to fix this, right?

David Kaufer [00:46:09–00:46:10]

Right.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:46:10–00:46:21]

And some of it is that. I'm not going to say it's not some of it, but it was like they wouldn't accept, they wouldn't approve my post. Well, then that just really made me mad. It really, really made me mad.

David Kaufer [00:46:21–00:46:22]

Yeah, well, of course.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:46:22–00:47:01]

My husband will say it's the short ones, and I'm only 5'1. And so my husband will say the short ones you don't want to make mad. And my stepdaughter's mother's like 5'9. So he went for it. He knows the differences of the two.

Between the two of us, right? And he's like, you get and you don't back down when you're mad. And so then I decided, well, I'm going to post publicly on a Facebook page. They can't shut me up on a public post. And I did.

And then all of a sudden I was getting anonymous tips from DDA workers being like, we know this is a problem, but they won't change it. All these parents—

Oh, wow.

People that had worked And they didn't call them day programs back before they— because it was in 2004 and '06 where they made the policy shift to where it was a work and employment-based services, where they had worked in these shops and they talked about how devastating it was for a lot of people when they went away. And a big thing you always hear is Willowbrook. I don't— I'm a child of the '80s.

Announcer [00:47:27–00:47:27]

Right.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:47:28–00:47:37]

They always compare like, oh, those day programs will be like Willowbrook. Well, that was, yeah, it was awful. And I made a post acknowledging that, but we know better. We're gonna do better. So—

David Kaufer [00:47:37–00:47:38]

You can do better, right?

Announcer [00:47:38–00:47:39]

Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:47:39–00:47:58]

Just like, so you're not ever gonna give us a chance because of like history? And I mean, there's things

from history that I don't necessarily agree with how gynecological care came about because I know the history of it, but it's still an important, an important part of women's health. Absolutely.

Right.

The same with, like, there's been abuse at daycare centers, at hospitals, nursing homes. We don't close those down because what we do is we put better regulations. We hold the people who did it accountable. We do all this stuff. We don't just say, you can't have it because abuse happened there. And so I kept on getting all this feedback. Well, my best friend and I, Once a year we'll have a few White Claws. And normally I'm a very, very private person. Like, some of the stuff my best friends obviously read it and they're like, you just never complain. It's just like what your life is. And they're like, I didn't realize all this stuff. And these are people that I call about every little thing. You spend a lot.

Yeah.

Yeah. Yeah.

David Kaufer [00:48:44–00:48:46]

I mean, they know your life, but they don't know your life.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:48:46–00:49:39]

Yeah. And they're like, oh my God. And so I just knew that And I had heard so many stories that there were so many other parents out there like me that had the same fears. So I was like, I don't want to be the face of this, but somebody's got to do it that can share their story and make them care why this matters so much. And it's hard for me to take credit for I've done something great, but it was all these people reaching out.

And sending me messages like, thank you. And it's like, you know, there are behaviors that come with this and those behaviors with autism, and not everybody, but it's going to be hard to make them employable even. And it just— nobody's talking about it.

David Kaufer [00:49:39–00:49:58]

And does that always have to be the metric for someone's worth, for their value in society? Yeah. I mean, to quote someone else, do they have to be employable and pay taxes? Is that the value that we're saying? Is that they pay taxes?

Angela Acres-Castro [00:49:58–00:50:29]

And right now, to me, Washington State has a very ableist system set up. You have to be able to do it. And I come to that determination not through— it's my opinion, but it's my opinion from the data. That they're publishing. I mean, and they were making employment the only choice and there was subpar minimum wage. So they weren't letting them have an option not to work. And then when they were working, they weren't even paying a minimum wage.

Announcer [00:50:29–00:50:30]

Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:50:30–00:50:42]

So it's just like there's a whole history of this and it's like, and they point to this 83% engagement rate. Well, yeah, of course it's going to be that high when that's the only service that you're providing.

David Kaufer [00:50:42–00:50:44]

It's the only thing out there.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:50:44–00:51:29]

Well, and then you'll go into the weeds and it's like, I was like, oh my God, I'm going to run out of ideas for posts. And then it's like, no, there's problems with how people can access community inclusion and all this stuff. So it's a never-ending thing of how Washington has chosen to structure its programs and how they are not working. And they're like, you're not going to make a lot of friends along the way doing this. But it's like, I don't really care.

I have 4 friends. Do I need more? But, and I'm not trying to fight with anybody, but I'm like, I think we judge a society how we take care of the most vulnerable among us. And right now, like, if you have an

IDD, I feel like you're left to the, left to the, you know, winds.

David Kaufer [00:51:29–00:51:30]

Whatever happens.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:51:30–00:51:35]

Yeah. Whatever happens happens. If you can't do this, you know, sorry about your bummed luck. And that's not good enough for me.

David Kaufer [00:51:37–00:52:18]

No, I think, I think you put it very well. I mean, I think it should be the, you know, one of the marks of our society, the marks, you know, the way that we measure ourselves as, as a society, as a state, as a country. You know, you could go on and on, but like you said, these are, these are individuals who need support, and we all need support in different ways, and there's different levels of support. And just because you need support doesn't lower your value as a human being, as you know, like you said. I mean, yeah, right.

I mean, oh yeah, you've got an amazing son who's loved and cared for, and he contributes to your life and so many other rich lives in the community. And, well, right, that's all valuable.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:52:18–00:52:37]

Yeah. And he's made me a better person. I would not be the person I am today if I was not his mom. We were always meant to be together. Left around the community. It's like, I mean, when he graduated, there were so many staff members that were crying because he was leaving there.

Announcer [00:52:37–00:52:38]

Oh, wow.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:52:38–00:53:50]

Because they're like, I'm going to miss my guy with a smile all the time. And they saw the beauty. And it's like, not only when they talk about it's a segregated setting, I'm like, if you saw them interact, Miles and his classmates interacting, and they were around the general their typical peers too, but they loved each other. They got each other. That's amazing that they had that.

Oh my God. You'll never go to a basketball game like Unified basketball. It is the best thing I've ever seen. And I loved every single game. They're great.

They're great. And then we look at it now. If somebody if women wanted to gather, if the elderly want to have an area, a neighborhood where you have to be 55 plus, we let 'em do it. But if a bunch of people who have IDD want to get together and go out into the community and go to their local fair or go, you know, to a pumpkin patch during the fall, and then they go back on and working on things that take 'em a little longer to catch onto, like for Miles, not stealing food at the grocery store.

Right.

And stuff like that. We treat it like, an institution. It's not the same thing. It is not the same thing as what happened in the '80s and '90s. And I think that Washington can give us a little bit more credit. We know that we've learned and we're not going to do that again.

David Kaufer [00:54:04–00:54:48]

Yeah, just give, give us the opportunity. So for those out there, again, this is, yeah, it's Washington State specific, but one of the reasons I wanted to talk to you, because again, you've, you've reached out to other states. And again, I think it's just such a great example, Angie, of someone who just said, you mentioned earlier, I don't want to—I didn't want to be the face. I don't want to do this, but someone's got to do the, you know, someone's got to roll up their sleeves and do this. And I think, you know, this is the world that we live in.

And this is what I want to encourage others to do. You may not think that you're the one who's going to create change or who can, you know, make something happen, or you may not want to be, you know, you would mean, but that's the way it happens. Like, this is, this is how activism happens.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:54:50–00:55:24]

Well, and I will, I mean, I'm not, I just ask my mom, my husband, my sisters. I am not one that just

throws in the towel when I think I'm right. I may retreat, but I come back and I just, I was going to think what, I just, it's not acceptable. Hold on, I got to think about what I had a thought, but ADD brain. So with me sharing my Stories, and I do try to discuss behaviors on my page, but again, I want to protect people's privacy and dignity.

Announcer [00:55:24–00:55:25]

Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:55:25–00:56:28]

And so I try to tell stories that still leave people's dignity intact. And I am surprised at the amount of messages that I get from parents saying, this is the first time I feel seen. This is the first time you're telling my story. And I don't have to give the nitty-gritty details of what I live with every day. And, you know, whatever those behaviors are, every single one of those people are loved people.

And I remember I had somebody tell me that they were really upset because somebody looked at their son and thought they belonged, needed special, like, you know, settings at school or something like that. And I said to that person, I said, You know, those people that look like they need those accommodations, they're very loved people too. And those families want you to see past the diagnosis or the looks and see the person that they love. So let's not ever judge anyone by just looking at them, because every single one of these people are loved individuals.

David Kaufer [00:56:28–00:56:38]

They are. And they all, you know, it's a cliché, but it's true. They all have incredible gifts and strengths of their own. They're smarter than people realize. They're more—

Angela Acres-Castro [00:56:38–00:56:39]

Oh God.

David Kaufer [00:56:39–00:56:45]

Funnier than people realize. There's, there's just, there's so much there. Yeah, I want to—

Angela Acres-Castro [00:56:45–00:57:02]

Yeah, Miles would flick over Legos so he could get out of speech therapy because he knew the kid would clear up the classroom. I'm like, don't—I mean, I knew exactly what he was doing too because I was like, do not—I said something to him, he's like, sorry, sorry. I was like, don't do that anymore. God, he gets the whole class upset because he didn't like speech therapy.

David Kaufer [00:57:03–00:57:05]

Still does. Yeah, I mean, that's very, that's very clever.

Yeah.

Um, okay, I want to jump ahead. We have a couple segments I want to get in here. Again, we've covered a lot of ground, which I appreciate so much. We're going to start with our first one, which is our Autism Tip of the Week.

Announcer [00:57:16–00:57:30]

Hey parents, gather around, it's time to speak. We're here with your tip of the week, strategies and wisdom just for you. Autism parents, we know what you go through.

David Kaufer [00:57:34–00:57:41]

All right, it's time for our weekly segment, our tip of the week. And Angie, I know that you came prepared for this. What, what is your tip of the week?

Angela Acres-Castro [00:57:41–00:57:53]

So, um, my tip of the week is if something doesn't make sense to you, keep on asking questions and don't stop until something— it makes sense to you.

David Kaufer [00:57:53–00:58:21]

I love that. I love that. I think that, I mean, that, that needs to be like engraved somewhere because I think that's Too often, again, speaking from personal experience, we accept things. We accept what's told to us or how things are presented when it comes to our kids who have support needs and don't ask questions, right? Or you're afraid to ask questions. You don't want to rock the boat. You don't want to

upset a teacher or administrator or whoever it may be. Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:58:22–00:58:27]

Yeah. You know, you're your kid's first and best advocate.

Absolutely.

So don't forget that.

David Kaufer [00:58:31–00:58:38]

Absolutely. That's great. All right, we're gonna jump ahead to Autism Fact or Fiction, and I know you have a great one here too, so let's get to that.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:58:38–00:58:45]

Get QuickTime ready, and here we go. This is Autism Fact or Fiction. We're breaking down what's real, what's rumor, and what might surprise you.

David Kaufer [00:58:45–00:58:56]

Let's go. All right, so again, this is where we debunk a stereotype or maybe share something that people don't know and say, you know, hey, is this, is this fact or fiction?

Angela Acres-Castro [00:58:57–00:59:03]

So I chose one for girls because they're so underrepresented with autism.

David Kaufer [00:59:03–00:59:03]

Yes.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:59:04–00:59:45]

Yes. It's often said that kids with autism don't have an imagination. Well, that is not really true, especially with girls can have like an overactive imagination. It's so realistic that they become part of that Imagination. And this is with my best friend's permission. Her daughter's on the spectrum. And when she was about 4, she thought she was Little Red Riding Hood. So she put her cape on, grabbed her basket, and headed out the front door to go to her grandma's house across town. So they can actually have an overactive imagination.

David Kaufer [00:59:45–00:59:52]

That's great. Yeah, you don't hear about that much. Like you said, kind of creativity or imagination.

Angela Acres-Castro [00:59:52–01:00:03]

No, she's really still like that too. So yeah, they do have— they can have quite active imaginations. So it is not true that they do not— it is fiction that they do not have imaginations.

David Kaufer [01:00:03–01:00:09]

Well, great, great example. All right, next up we have our parent confession.

Announcer [01:00:22–01:00:45]

Morning routines can go astray. Found socks in the fridge one day. Laughter's the best remedy. Hey, we're just finding our own way. Mom-Dad Confessions every week, sharing joys and moments we seek. Honest tales that make us unique. Join the club, we're never—

David Kaufer [01:00:45–01:01:03]

All right. And this is the part, as I always say, this is where kind of we, we share our humanity and we talk about things that we may look back. And I think every parent listening or watching has, you know, one decision that they probably still replay in their head. Um, and Angie, do you have something that you want to share?

Announcer [01:01:03–01:01:04]

Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [01:01:04–01:02:25]

And I'll, I think I told you Miles and I were like, if you ever read The Scarlet Letter, we were like Hester and Pearl because We were the— especially for my age group, I was the only one that had a child with an intellectual disability. So I was really going at it on my own. Like, I didn't have anybody to turn to. And my biggest regret is probably not listening to my gut instinct when I thought something wasn't good for him. He was in a school setting and it wasn't the best for him.

And I was convinced by a few different angles to leave him in that setting because if a lawsuit came down the pike, it would help. And I didn't ever want to sue. I didn't want that stress or whatever. Nobody wants that, right? And so he was stuck in that classroom for however many years, and I should have just had him moved out of it.

I should have just moved him out and not listened to that. And I was miserable the whole time he was in it and he was miserable. He actually kind of picked up some maladaptive behaviors while in there. And so it just, I should have, the first sign, it was like 2 months in, 3 months in, it wasn't going to go well. And it never did.

It never changed.

Announcer [01:02:25–01:02:27]

Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [01:02:27–01:02:32]

So go with your gut. If you think something's wrong, It most likely is.

David Kaufer [01:02:33–01:02:42]

Yeah, I, I totally agree. And again, uh, you know, it's one of those things that is a true confession to something I think unfortunately many of us share. Hindsight's 20/20.

Yeah.

Um, you know, again, for those listening, watching, and, you know, we want, we want you to learn—excuse me— from our experiences, you know, learn from some of the things that we wish we did different or better looking back. But we like to look We like to wrap up on a positive note, Angie, and talk about light on the spectrum. And so, you know, we're gonna, we're gonna focus on that at the end here.

Angela Acres-Castro [01:03:07–01:03:30]

Light on the spectrum, a moment, person, or story bringing something good. It feels hopeful, grounded, not performative. All right.

David Kaufer [01:03:30–01:03:36]

So like I said, we like to end on a positive note. And I know that you have something that you can share that I think will—

Angela Acres-Castro [01:03:36–01:03:39]

Okay. And I think people forgot what I wrote on this part.

David Kaufer [01:03:39–01:03:41]

Okay. Well, yeah. Do you remember? I can cue it back up. Okay.

Angela Acres-Castro [01:03:41–01:03:44]

Do you want to read it to me? Because I'm like, God, I didn't write so much.

David Kaufer [01:03:44–01:03:49]

So I'll just ask you this. When people ask you who Miles is today, how do you describe him?

Angela Acres-Castro [01:03:50–01:04:49]

He's the happiest guy I know. And for someone who, communication doesn't come easy for him, it doesn't mean he's not leaving his mark on this world. He definitely is. And you know that when you go around town with him and people know who he is and they're like, hi, Miles. And they know who he is. And I think everybody that encounters him in their life, most people think that they're better off because they know him. I know I am. I mean, he's made me be a more compassionate, accepting, and understanding person that I wouldn't have been without being his mom. And he'll leave his mark on this world one way or another because— He's just so wonderful. I mean, he really is.

And so—

David Kaufer [01:04:49–01:05:03]

I love that. And I think that's— it comes through in so many ways. I think one of the things you had mentioned was, which again, I think is another great mantra we need to put up somewhere, is you don't need words to change people's hearts. Yes.

Angela Acres-Castro [01:05:04–01:05:10]

And he does that. He most certainly does. He's He's a great guy and I'm very lucky.

David Kaufer [01:05:10–01:05:28]

So Angie, tell people about the Facebook group. For those, again, whether you live in Washington State or not, you might be interested because there are a lot— you, you post a lot of great, uh, interesting facts and information for parents, you know. And, and again, those others might be inspired to do something similar where they live.

Angela Acres-Castro [01:05:28–01:05:59]

Okay, so my Facebook page is called A Place to Belong in Washington. Now it's not spelled the way it should be because I didn't mean to save it when I did, but it just— too fast of a brain. But basically, I share stories, I share my own stories, I share information from state reports. And also, I have people from California following me just because, like I said, they feel seen in the stories that are being told.

Announcer [01:05:59–01:06:00]

Yeah, exactly.

Angela Acres-Castro [01:06:01–01:06:22]

I guess they don't feel like they've gotten that in another place or whatever, but it really is good. And we will not make a change in Washington unless we have tons of people banding together saying, no more, this has to change, we want different. So the more voices we have in the fight, the better we are.

David Kaufer [01:06:22–01:06:31]

And it's growing. I mean, since I've joined, since we've connected, which I think has been a couple of weeks now, it seems like it's growing rapidly.

Angela Acres-Castro [01:06:31–01:06:37]

I started July 5th at 8:00, 7:30 at night, and it's already at like 503 people.

David Kaufer [01:06:37–01:06:44]

Yeah. So it's already, I mean, just in a couple of weeks. And so we'll see that exponential growth. Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [01:06:44–01:06:56]

It'll shock me. Like something that I, like this morning's post, I was like, I didn't think it, it was like kind of a boring one for me. And then all of a sudden I look down and there's like 12 shares. I'm like, at 10:00 this morning, I'm like, whoa, okay.

David Kaufer [01:06:56–01:07:22]

Good for Walk Club. That's kind of the beauty of of Facebook or social media again, and we're being advocates. Yeah, I, I do my share of posting, as I've talked about, articles, things that I write. And like you said, there's this— it's, it's just, it's so interesting because there's things that you write, posts that you have, you're like, oh, this is fire, this is so great. And then like, it's crickets, you know. And then there's nothing— I'm just going to share this. And then like—

Angela Acres-Castro [01:07:22–01:07:30]

I told my sister I would compare it to Ralphie off of A Christmas Story when he's writing about the Red Ryder BB gun and he thinks that people are going to be falling over hearing about the—
Reading this report.

And then he gets I'm like, I don't want it to be a rowdy post.

David Kaufer [01:07:34–01:07:36]

That's great.

Angela Acres-Castro [01:07:36–01:08:22]

So yeah, it is. And it's actually the shares really do a lot because that gets the information out to other people that don't know that this problem exists in our state. That's like, all engagement is great. I love it all. And it makes me feel like being so vulnerable makes it worthwhile when people interact and share their— and tell me that they understand where I'm coming from.

Because I tend not to put my heart on my sleeves like this. But it definitely— those shares are very, very important to get the message out to everyone so that it's not just me yelling into the abyss

anymore. And when I would talk to people that I thought could help, I felt like my cries were falling on deaf ears.

David Kaufer [01:08:22–01:08:23]

Yeah.

Angela Acres-Castro [01:08:25–01:08:41]

Yeah, just like, I mean, I don't know if that's the politically correct term to use anymore, but that's what it's like. No one was paying attention. There was a pat on the head and like, oh dear, dear, I know that's too bad. And then onto the next subject. And it was like, no, this is really important.

David Kaufer [01:08:41–01:08:49]

Well, keep fighting. You have me and others on your side. I really appreciate what you're doing. Thank you.

Angela Acres-Castro [01:08:49–01:08:52]

And I appreciate you Yeah. Giving me the time too.

David Kaufer [01:08:52–01:09:21]

Oh yeah, no, this is great. And so for, again, for all the listeners, everyone out there, thank you for being part of this community as well. As Angie said, it is great to get feedback. Feel free to drop me a note, david.kaufer@hey.com. Check me out at Kaufer Insights on Substack, uh, and leave us a review or rating on Spotify, Apple Music, wherever you find your podcast. Uh, until next time, we'll catch you on the lighter side of the spectrum.